

3.4 Population distribution by agro-ecological zones

For purposes of socio-economic analysis, the country is divided into agro-ecological zones. The districts comprising each zone are as follows :-

- Zone I - Colombo, Kalutara, Galle and Matara districts
- Zone II - Hambantota, Moneragala, Amparai, Polonnaruwa, Anuradhapura and Puttalam districts
- Zone III - Jaffna, Mannar, Vavuniya, Batticaloa and Trincomalee districts
- Zone IV - Kandy, Matale, Nuwara Eliya, Badulla, Ratnapura, Kegalle and Kurunegala districts

Zones I and IV are mostly in the Wet Zone while Zones II and III are the Dry Zone.

The Table 3.4 shows the land area, population and density of each of 4 zones at the censuses of 1963 and 1971.

TABLE 3.4 : POPULATION DISTRIBUTION AND POPULATION DENSITY IN THE 4 AGRO-ECOLOGICAL ZONES, - 1963 to 1971

Zone	Land Area		Population in 1000				Density per Sq.Mile		% Incre
	Sq.Mls.	%	1963	%	1971	%	1963	1971	
I	2,540	10.3	4,022.3	37.7	4723.4	37.0	1581	1861	17.
II	10,125	40.5	1,314.6	12.5	1736.7	13.7	130	172	32.
III	5,316	21.3	1,076.1	10.3	1319.6	10.2	202	248	22.
IV	6,981	27.9	4,196.1	39.5	4910.2	39.1	600	702	17.
Sri Lanka	24,962	100	10,582.1	100	12689.9	100	423	508	20.

One of the significant changes in the distribution of the population among the 4 zones, between the two Censuses, is the drift of the population towards Zone II where more land is available for cultivation. The proportion of population in the Wet Zone, (zones I and IV), where the demand for land is higher, had declined from 77.2 in 1963 to 76.1 in 1971. This decline could be attributed chiefly to migration from the Wet Zone. Zone II contained 12.5 percent of the population in 1963. Its share of the total population increased to 13.7 percent in 1971. Zone III shows only a small change from 10.3 percent in 1963 to 10.2 percent in 1971. Zone IV consists of 40 percent of the total land area, and the restoration of irrigation schemes and establishment of major colonization schemes in this zone have been the factors behind the recent migration of people into this zone from the Wet Zone.

The density of Zone I was the highest with 1861 persons per square mile in 1971. This represents an increase of 280 (or 17 percent) over the density in 1963. It is of interest to note that the density of Zone I is nearly two and a half times that of its nearest rival namely Zone IV. The density of Zone II is less than one-tenth that of Zone I.